INDO JAPAN
CONCLAVE



HOW TO BREAK THE SPEE

FROM GEO-POLITICS TO GREEN ENERGY AND FROM INVESTMENT TO AUTOMOBILES AND CONSUMER GOODS, THE INDIA TODAY INDO JAPAN CONCLAVE 2022 SET THE AGENDA FOR THE HIGH GROWTH THE TWO NATIONS ASPIRE TO

A day before Christmas, India celebrated 20 years of its most extensive metro rail network—the Delhi Metro. Constructed with Japanese expertise, it has revolutionised urban transport in India. Indeed, India and Japan share a unique bonding, marking 70 years of diplomatic ties in 2022. Yet, whether business or strategic, the overall performance has been underwhelming. The India Today Indo Japan Conclave 2022 on December 19 in New Delhi touched upon several parts of this multi-faceted relationship, and set the agenda for high growth. While delivering the inaugural keynote address, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said that Japan and India have a positive history that will be an asset in future. Japan, he said, is perceived in India as a model of harmonising modernity and tradition. "A strong national consensus exists in India on developing ties with it," Jaishankar said. Paying tribute to the late Shinzo Abe, he said that the former Japanese PM gave a personal touch to India-Japan relations—from trade and culture to a strategic partnership. He added that Japan has been a catalyst of change—Maruti brought a lifestyle shift and the Metro an experience of urbanisation. Beginning his address in Hindi, Hiroshi Suzuki, Ambassador of Japan to India, said India and Japan have targeted a ¥5 trillion partnership in the next five years. Suzuki emphasised his desire to work closely with India in 2023, as Japan hosts the G7 meeting and India has the presidency of G20. While there has been an increase in Japanese investments in India, they still haven't translated into greater trade. Japanese companies have been working with India on multiple rail and infrastructure projects like the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train. Japanese firms are also collaborating with India on the construction of roads in the Northeast. India-Japan strategic ties have also deepened in recent years.

The day-long event witnessed multiple sessions, ranging from discussions on infrastructure, the green imperative to consumer goods and geopolitics in the Indo-Pacific. Stalwarts of both nations from various fields attended the sessions. ■

—***Pradip R. Sagar***

Photographs by **RAJWANT RAWAT**